

Couples Communication Worksheet

Building Healthy Dialogue Patterns

Use this worksheet together as a couple or individually to prepare for a conversation about a difficult topic. The goal is to express needs without blame and listen without defensiveness.

Partner A Name: _____ Partner B Name: _____ Date: _____

STEP 1: Identify the Issue

Describe the situation factually (no judgments or labels):

STEP 2: Express Feelings Using "I" Statements

Formula: "When [situation], I feel [emotion], because [reason]. I need [request]."

Partner A:

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

Partner B:

When: _____

I feel: _____

Because: _____

I need: _____

STEP 3: Active Listening Check

After your partner shares, reflect back what you heard:

"What I hear you saying is..."

Communication Styles & Action Plan

STEP 4: Identify Your Communication Patterns

Check patterns you recognize in yourself:

- ☐ Stonewalling (shutting down, giving silent treatment)
- ☐ Criticism (attacking character instead of behavior)
- ☐ Contempt (sarcasm, eye-rolling, mockery)
- ☐ Defensiveness (making excuses, counter-attacking)
- ☐ Flooding (becoming overwhelmed, unable to think clearly)
- ☐ Pursuer pattern (chasing, demanding response)
- ☐ Withdrawer pattern (pulling away, avoiding conflict)

STEP 5: Our Agreement

One thing I will try to do more:

One thing I will try to do less:

Our safe word/signal for taking a break:

We agree to revisit this conversation on (date):

Partner A Signature: _____ Partner B Signature: _____